THE COMPLIMENT TRAP · A 10-MINUTE POST-CALL DEBRIEF

# Was that interview good, or did they just like you?

Do this within ten minutes of hanging up, before you message your co-founder "they loved it". That is exactly when a compliment quietly turns into "they'd pay", and the notes never get written.

**10 MINUTES** | ONE SHEET PER CALL | PRINT FIVE COPIES

## EVERYTHING THEY SAID GOES IN ONE OF FOUR BINS

### COMPLIMENT

Praise for you or your idea.

> *"That's a really cool idea."*

**WORTH: NOTHING. IT COST THEM NOTHING TO SAY.**

### FLUFF

Generic claims, hypotheticals, "I would", "I usually", "people like me".

> *"I'd definitely use something like that."*

**WORTH: NOTHING. IT'S A FORECAST.**

### FACT

Something that already happened: a specific time, workaround, cost or person.

> *"Last March I lost two days rebuilding a client's invoice history."*

**WORTH: REAL. THIS IS DATA.**

### COMMITMENT

They gave up something now: time, reputation or money.

> *"Let me introduce you to our finance lead."*

**WORTH: MOST. THIS IS EVIDENCE.**

The idea that a compliment is worth nothing, and a commitment of time, reputation or money is worth a lot, comes from Rob Fitzpatrick's *The Mom Test*. This sheet just makes you sort the pile while it's still warm.

**"they loved it" is not a finding.**



FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

WHO (ROLE, NOT NAME) _____ DATE _____ THE ASSUMPTION I WAS TESTING _____

Write down the eight things they said that you remember most, as close to word-for-word as you can. Then tick one bin for each. Don't tidy them up or round them up to what you wanted to hear.

| | WHAT THEY ACTUALLY SAID | COMPLI-MENT | FLUFF | FACT | COMMIT-MENT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 2 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 3 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 4 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 5 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 6 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 7 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| 8 | | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| | TOTAL TICKS → | --- | --- | --- | --- |

**WHICH QUESTION INVITED THE COMPLIMENTS?**

**THE SINGLE BEST FACT I HEARD**

**DID THE ASSUMPTION MOVE?**

Only facts and commitments are allowed to move it. Compliments and fluff can't.

↑ STRONGER ↓ WEAKER — NO CHANGE

**THE NEXT STEP THEY AGREED TO (IF NONE, WRITE "NONE")**

# What your ticks are telling you.

These aren't scores. They point at what to change before the next call.

| | |
|---|---|
| MOSTLY COMPLIMENTS | **You probably pitched.** Once your idea is in the room, people react to it politely. Next time, hold the solution back until the last five minutes, or leave it out entirely. |
| MOSTLY FLUFF | **You asked about the future.** "Would you…" and "how often do you…" get you forecasts. Swap them for "tell me about the last time…". Field sheet 01 drills exactly this. |
| FACTS, NO COMMITMENT | **A good conversation that didn't go anywhere.** You learned something real. Next time, ask for a next step before you hang up (see the ladder below). A "no" is information too. |
| AT LEAST ONE COMMITMENT | **That's evidence.** Write it in your assumption list with the date and who it was. One commitment from a stranger outweighs a pile of compliments from friends. |

## THE COMMITMENT LADDER: ASK FOR ONE RUNG BEFORE YOU HANG UP

### TIME

- A follow-up call with a clear purpose
- Looking at a rough sketch with you
- Trying a manual version for a week

### REPUTATION

- An introduction to a colleague with the same problem
- An intro to whoever signs off the spending

### MONEY

- A pre-order or deposit
- A letter of intent
- Paying for the manual version

The time, reputation and money categories follow *The Mom Test*. Reputation-type asks usually fit B2B better than consumer products.

## ACROSS YOUR CALLS: STICK THE TOTALS HERE

| CALL | WHO · compliments not shrinking? check your questions before you blame the market | COMPL. | FLUFF | FACTS | COMMIT. | MOVED? |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | | | | |
| 2 | | | | | | |
| 3 | | | | | | |
| 4 | | | | | | |
| 5 | | | | | | |

PAPER DOESN'T ANSWER BACK

## Find the compliment-bait before the call.

This sheet tells you *after* the call that a question invited a compliment. Unassumed lets you find out *before*: rehearse against a synthetic customer who objects, digresses and won't be led, then see which of your questions did the leading. It's practice, not proof. Only a real customer is evidence.

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